

Prunus armeniaca (Rosaceae)

Apricot

Description Sturdy deciduous tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has finely serrated oval leaves, clusters of white (or, rarely, pink) 5-petaled flowers, and lightly freckled pale yellow to deep purple fruits.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China and Japan, apricot is now cultivated in Asia, North Africa, and California. The fruit is collected when ripe in late summer.



Apricot seeds yield laetrile, which has been used as a controversial treatment for cancer.

Parts Used Fruit, seeds, bark.

Constituents Apricot fruit contains fruit sugars, vitamins, and iron. The seeds contain up to 8% amygdalin, the cyanogenic glycoside that yields laetrile and hydrocyanic (prussic) acid. The bark contains tannins.

History & Folklore In India and China, the apricot has been appreciated for well over 2,000 years. Dong Feng, a physician who practiced at the end of the 2nd century CE, is said to have asked for his payment in apricot trees.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Apricot fruit is nutritious, cleansing, and mildly laxative. A decoction of the astringent bark soothes inflamed and irritated skin conditions. Though the seeds contain highly toxic prussic acid, they are prescribed in small amounts in the Chinese tradition as a treatment for coughs, asthma, and wheezing, and for excessive mucus production and constipation. An extract from the seeds, laetrile, has been used in Western medicine as a controversial (and illegal in the U.S.) treatment for cancer. The seeds also yield a fixed oil, similar to almond oil (from *P. amygdalus*), that is often used in the formulation of cosmetics.

Research Chinese trials show that apricot seed paste helps combat vaginal infection.

Caution Apricot seeds are highly toxic in all but the smallest amounts and should not be consumed.

Prunus avium & *P. cerasus*

(Rosaceae)

Sweet Cherry, & Tart Cherry

Description Deciduous shrub or tree growing to 26 ft (8 m). It has reddish-brown bark, oval to elliptical leaves, clusters of 2–6 white flowers, and almost spherical red fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to southwestern Asia, cherry is naturalized in Europe and cultivated in temperate regions around the world. The stems and ripe fruit are collected in summer.

Parts Used Stems, fruit.

Constituents Cherry stems contain phenols, including salicylic acid, and tannins. Cherry fruit contains anthocyanins and flavonoids, including quercetin, carotenoids, sugars, fruit acids, vitamin C, and melatonin.

History & Folklore The 16th-century herbalist John Gerard recorded the French custom of hanging cherries in houses to ward off fever.

Medicinal Actions & Uses In European herbal medicine, cherries and cherry stems have long been used for their diuretic and astringent properties. They have been prescribed for cystitis, nephritis, and urinary retention, and for arthritic problems, notably gout. Cherries and cherry juice can be useful in treating gout and arthritic problems. Their fruit sugar content makes them mildly laxative.



Sweet cherry fruit and stems have been harvested for medicinal use since classical times.

Research In a 2012 American-Australian clinical study involving 633 people with gout, the risk of an acute gout attack was reduced by 35% for those taking cherry extract. One laboratory study

concluded that the anti-inflammatory activities of anthocyanins within cherry fruit are comparable to those of ibuprofen.

Caution The seeds are toxic and should not be consumed.

Prunus mume (Rosaceae)

Asian Plum, Wu Mei (Chinese)

Description Deciduous tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has pointed oval to elliptical leaves, white flowers, and yellow fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, Asian plum grows wild and is planted in the southern and eastern provinces. The fruit is picked in late spring.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Asian plum contains fruit acids and sugars, vitamin C, and plant sterols.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The sour-tasting astringent Asian plum is used in Chinese medicine to counter diarrhea and dysentery, to stop bleeding, and to ease coughs. It may also be effective in expelling hookworms. Externally, a plaster of the fruit is applied to the sites of removed corns and warts to hasten healing.

Research Laboratory research undertaken in China indicates that the fruit of Asian plum has antibiotic properties.

Prunus serotina (Rosaceae)

Wild Cherry

Description Deciduous tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has elliptical to oblong leaves, white flowers, and purple-black fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, wild cherry grows throughout much of the U.S. It is cultivated in central Europe for its timber. The bark is collected in late summer and early autumn.

Part Used Inner bark.

Constituents Wild cherry contains prunasin (a cyanogenic glycoside that yields hydrocyanic acid), benzaldehyde, eudesmic acid, coumarins, and tannins. Prunasin reduces the cough reflex.

History & Folklore Cherokee women traditionally took wild cherry bark to ease labor pain. Other Native Americans used it in the treatment of coughs and colds, hemorrhoids, and diarrhea. European settlers learned of the bark's medicinal properties, and in the 19th century it became a widely used remedy.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Figuring in official pharmacopoeias and much used in the Anglo-American tradition, wild cherry bark is an